

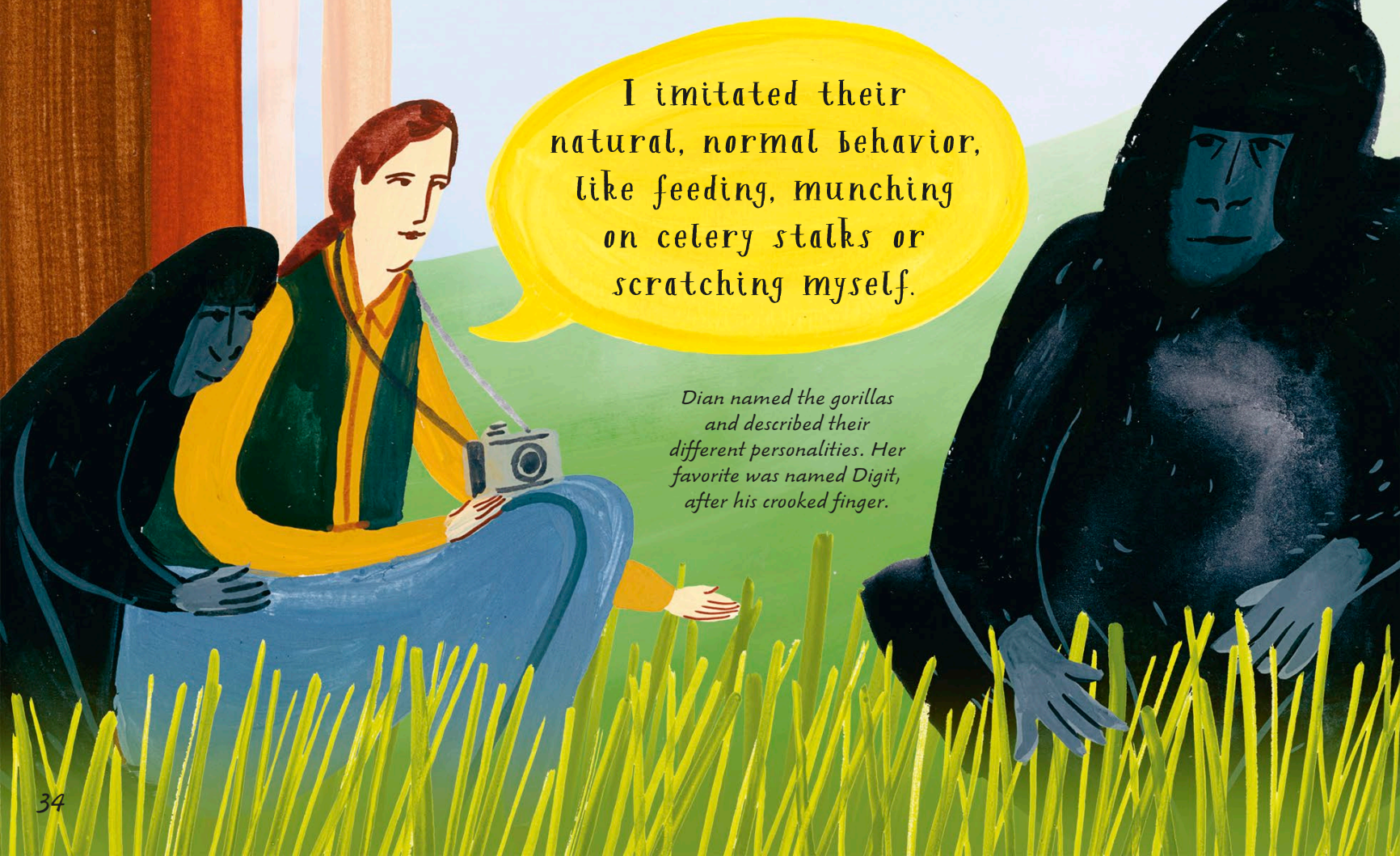
An illustration at the top of the page shows a black gorilla sitting on a tree branch next to a portrait of Dian Fossey. They are surrounded by green and yellow leaves. The background is a light blue sky.

DIAN FOSSEY

American primatologist

1932–1985

Wild mountain gorillas are among the world's rarest animals, living in just two areas of east-central Africa. In the 1960s, few people had ever seen a mountain gorilla up close. Movies and stories, such as *King Kong*, had given these great apes a reputation for being fierce and dangerous. Dian Fossey was one of the first scientists to live alongside mountain gorillas, and her discoveries changed our ideas about apes, and humans, forever. Dian set up a small research station in the forest, high up in the Virunga Mountains in Rwanda. Here, she could watch mountain gorillas every day.

An illustration at the bottom of the page shows Dian Fossey sitting on the ground in a grassy field, holding a camera. A black gorilla is sitting next to her. A yellow speech bubble contains text. Another gorilla is visible in the background on the right.

I imitated their natural, normal behavior, like feeding, munching on celery stalks or scratching myself.

Dian named the gorillas and described their different personalities. Her favorite was named Digit, after his crooked finger.